

Is your workplace a Kind or Wicked environment?

Drawn from the research in *Range*, this distinction tells you whether your organization runs on repeating patterns and clear rules (**Kind**) or operates in a complex, unpredictable reality where rules are incomplete and feedback is delayed (**Wicked**).

Knowing your environment is critical for designing **high-impact internships**. For each question, choose the description that best fits your current team or project.

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WORK PROCESSES

The nature of work processes on your team

☐ Work is primarily procedural — following a standardized "script" or manual reliably leads to success.

☐ Work involves "ill-structured" problems with no set script; the path to a solution is negotiated through creative means.

2

THE FEEDBACK LOOP

How feedback reaches people doing the work

☐ Feedback is immediate, accurate, and clearly tied to specific actions — like a game of chess or golf.

☐ Feedback is often delayed, ambiguous, or non-existent; short-term "progress" doesn't always equal deep learning.

3

PROBLEM VISIBILITY

How problems tend to show up

☐ Problems are well-defined and easily recognized from past experience (surface analogies).

☐ Big wins require reframing the problem entirely; "outside-in" thinking from someone far from the surface is often needed.

4

THE ROLE OF EXPERTISE

What specialized experience predicts here

☐ Specialized experience is a reliable predictor of success — more data consistently leads to better results.

☐ Experience is a "double-edged sword" that can breed over-confidence or "functional fixedness."

5

ADAPTABILITY TO CHANGE

How stable the environment is over time

☐ The environment is stable, built on repeating patterns that hold consistent over years or decades.

☐ The environment shifts rapidly; what worked yesterday might "lead into a wall" today, demanding constant recalibration.

6

THINKING STYLES ENCOURAGED

The thinking style your culture rewards

☐ We prioritize "vertical thinking" — deep specialization, where people focus on a single domain.

☐ We prioritize "lateral thinking" — repurposing what's available and connecting across disparate domains.

7

USE OF ANALOGIES

How people reason from past situations

☐ We rely on "surface" analogies — if we fixed a sink once, we use that exact method next time.

☐ We rely on "deep" analogical thinking — spotting conceptual similarities across domains that look unrelated.

8

DECISION-MAKING CONTEXT

The conditions you make decisions under

☐ Decisions follow objective, repeating rules where the "win" condition is clear to everyone.

☐ Decisions involve high uncertainty; we work with "provisional knowledge" and constant experimentation.